

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

## CORE FORMULA

Notice the specific work -> Name it aloud -> Do not qualify

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one piece of effort you noticed today that would normally go unacknowledged. Say it without qualifying it or immediately moving on.

## BEST FOR

- Managing or leading people
- Motivating someone who is working hard but not being recognised
- Strengthening loyalty and trust
- Preventing burnout in yourself and others

## PHRASE BANK

### Effort Acknowledgements · Naming the work

- "I can see how much work went into that."
- "That took real effort and it shows."
- "I noticed how much you put into this — I wanted to say it."
- "That was not easy and you did it anyway."
- "I know that took longer than it should have — and you still got it done."
- "The amount of care in that was visible."
- "That was a lot to carry and you handled it."
- "I saw what went into this. I did not want to let it pass."

### Specific Effort · Naming the particular thing

- "The preparation you put into that meeting was clear."
- "You did not have to go that far — and you did."
- "That was more thorough than it needed to be, and it made the difference."
- "You stayed through the hard part without cutting corners."
- "I noticed you did X even though nobody asked you to."

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Moving straight to the next task without acknowledgement  
Better: Good work on that.  
**Best: I know how much work went into that. I did not want to move past it without saying so.**
- Weak: Generic praise: 'You worked so hard!'  
Better: That was a demanding piece of work.  
**Best: The preparation you put into that presentation was clear — especially under that timeline.**
- Weak: Backhanded acknowledgement: 'Finally got there!'  
Better: It took a while but we got there.  
**Best: Clean acknowledgement of the effort, no qualifiers.**

## DECISION TREE

### **If Someone finishes a difficult piece of work**

Acknowledge the work before moving to the next item.

*"Before we move on — I want to say that took real effort and it shows."*

### **If Someone is doing invisible work that goes unnoticed**

Name it specifically and without prompting.

*"I noticed you have been doing X — that does not go unnoticed."*

### **If You want to acknowledge effort but do not want to sound patronising**

Keep it simple and specific. One sentence. No fuss.

*"That took a lot. I wanted to say so."*

### **If The result was good but the effort was exceptional**

Acknowledge the effort separately from the result.

*"The result speaks for itself — but I also wanted to name what it took to get there."*

## **SCENARIOS**

### **Team member delivers after a difficult sprint**

Name the effort before moving to what comes next. — "Before we get into the next phase — I want to acknowledge what that just took."

### **Colleague going through a hard period personally while maintaining output**

Name the effort without making it about the personal situation. — "I see what you are carrying right now. I wanted to say it."

### **Peer who quietly fixed a problem nobody else noticed**

Name the specific invisible work. — "I noticed you sorted that out on your own. That is the kind of thing that keeps things working."

### **Child or young person who tried hard regardless of outcome**

Acknowledge the trying, not just the result. — "I saw how hard you worked on that. That matters more than the score."

## **WHEN NOT TO USE**

- When the effort was poor and naming it implies the outcome is acceptable.
- When managing underperformance — naming effort can inadvertently reward the wrong behaviour.
- When your acknowledgement would be read as performative because no real follow-through is planned.

## **7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL**

### **Day 1 — Notice before speaking**

In one interaction today, pause before moving to the next topic and ask: 'Did I acknowledge what just happened?'

### **Day 2 — The specific naming**

Give one acknowledgement that names the specific work rather than just 'good job.'

### **Day 3 — Invisible work**

Acknowledge one person doing work that nobody else is noticing.

### **Day 4 — Effort vs outcome**

Practise separating acknowledgement of effort from assessment of result.

### **Day 5 — No qualifier**

Give one acknowledgement with no 'but', no 'although', and no 'next time' after it.

### **Day 6 — Written acknowledgement**

Send one short message to someone acknowledging a specific effort.

### **Day 7 — Calibration**

Did acknowledgements land well? Were any too vague? Did any feel like performance rather than genuine notice?

## **AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I notice the effort before commenting on the result?
- Did I name the specific work — not just 'good job'?

- Did I say it without qualifying or immediately pivoting to the next ask?
- Was my acknowledgement genuine, not performative?
- Did I give the acknowledgement at the right moment — not too late?
- Did I acknowledge invisible or low-profile work that would normally go unnoticed?
- Did it land as genuine rather than managerial technique?